

Charybdis & McDuffie
Sierra Club Sierra Peak Section (SPS) Peaks ____
September 11th to the 13th

This weekend was originally going to be the final capper trip for the entire summer's worth of Sierra trips. The entire reason the trip came about was because I happened across the following image:



This looked so cool I decided I had to go there. So, I started researching several months and many cancelations later one of the WTC students from this year named Jason Stone and I were headed for Bishop, CA.

Due to the fact we would be camping in a National Park as opposed to the National Forest wilderness permits have to be picked up in person instead of calling and arranging an afterhour's pickup. As a result I flew home from Boise a day early and left home in the wee hours of the morning with the general plan of getting to Bishop and spending the day working from a coffee shop. Yes, I'm now full on consultant trash.

My one stalwart participant, Jason Stone, met me in Bishop. Jason had been in the Sierra Club Wilderness Travel Course (WTC) I volunteer to teach though he was in the other group and I had had a chance to meet him and play around on rock during the mosquito and lightning infested Mt Pickering trip several months ago.

Jason had driven up early also and was planning to hike in a day early and fish some of the backcountry lakes behind Sabrina (our trailhead). As I was required to work we made plans to meet the following morning at a backcountry lake about 7 miles in and he went off to play while I went to sit and make a nuisance of myself in the local Looney Bean coffee shop for the next 8 hours or so.

Finally it was 5 pm and after a last few hurried emails I stowed my laptop, ditched the cotton clothing, and hopped in my truck to take off for the wilderness.



I hiked in alone two or three miles in to Blue Lake before it became too dark to follow the trail. I decided it was best to call it a night and found a nice flat spot out of view of the trail, laid out my pad, and had a wonderful night sleeping under the stars.

I set my alarm to wake me at 4:30 am thinking I could eat, get packed, and be off down the trail at dawn. Unfortunately I didn't reset my travel alarm from Boise time. I realized my error as I was slurping down an extremely potent cup of instant coffee and happened to glance at my altimeter watch. 3:45 am. Oops.

Not being able to sleep I hung out for quite a while until it was light enough to see and then finally set off down the trail.



It was a beautiful morning and I made good time though the trail became a bit indistinct here and there.

The trail ended at Hungry Packer Lake and not seeing any sign of Jason I continued on to our meeting place at Echo Lake. The terrain was now basically cross country, hopping over a ridge and traversing a hillside before boulder hopping to reach the lake itself. Jason caught up with me around here as I'd somehow gotten ahead of him.



We set off across the boulders at a decent clip and climbed up to a remote and beautiful lake called Echo Lake. It shares its name with a col which was the major obstacle between us and the area we wanted to camp in.



It's towards the right of the bowl.



There you go, to the right of the dark rock.

The reason I had us come in this route is the area around Charybdis is hard to get to without a 30 mile hike in and I only had 3 days total to make this trip happen.

As you can see we had quite a climb to get there but first there was one more surprise. As we crossed the glacier we came across an airplane wreck.



The remains of a plane were quite a mess and I can only imagine how bad it would be to survive and be stuck up that high in the dead of winter. Sure enough when I got home I did a little digging and found the crash had happened in 1993 and all four passengers had died. Apparently most of the wreckage was removed but there's still quite a bit up there with the occasional piece of clothing still stuck inside.

After taking a few pictures we continued up towards Echo Col. As expected the col was class 3 which was a bit of a challenge with full packs on but nothing we couldn't handle.

Just as we reached the top of the col we heard thunder off in the background. This encouraged us to climb a bit faster.



We made it over with care and found ourselves looking down on the middle of nowhere.



After descending several miles we came to the one trail that ran through the area, the John Muir Trail / Pacific Crest Trail. We encountered a few thru hikers that were 3-6 days in to the 211 mile JMT. We chatted for a bit then continued down the trail to Helene Lake where we headed cross country even deeper to a lake without a name other than an elevation, Lake 11,828.





Finally we reached a bowl with a small lake in the middle which would be our home base for the next two nights. We found a small flat patch and set up camp.



We were completely alone back here except for the pikas.

Jason had brought this.

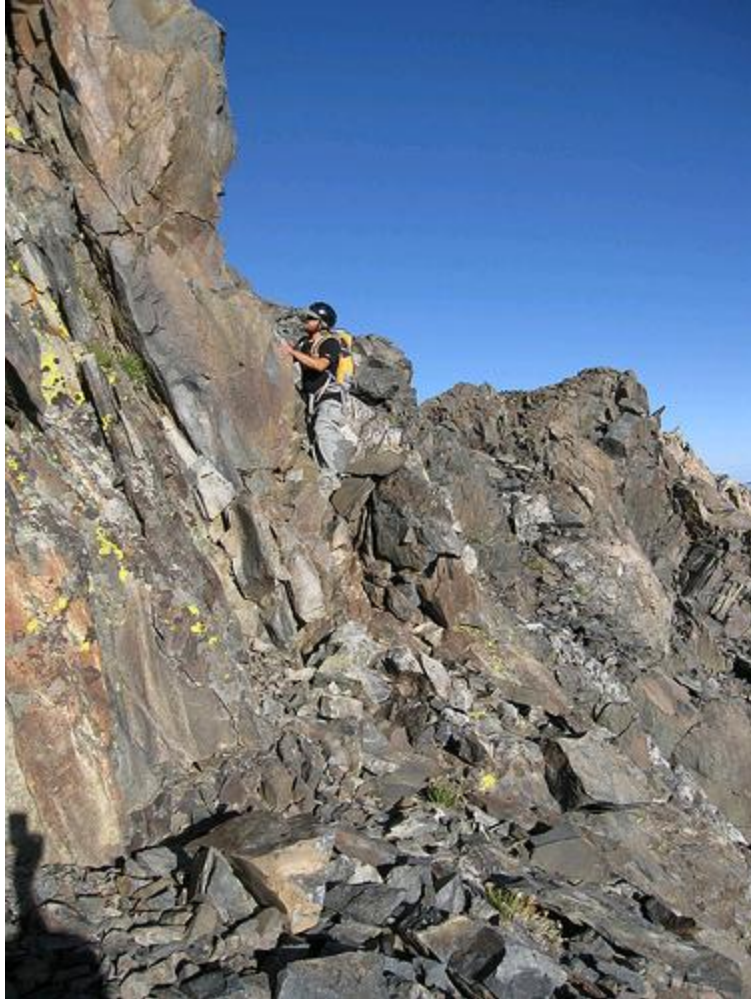


For a moment I was convinced I was out in the wilderness with a nutcase who for some reason was carrying around a bladder filled with human waste. He quickly assured me it was in fact a homemade mojito and I quit reaching for the duct tape to tie him up.



The next morning I had us out of camp at sunrise heading for the first peak, Charybdis.

It was a fairly standard and fun Sierra climb as they go, starting out with climbing up a rocky ridge and ending up in some solid 3rd class.



Soon we made the summit ridge and found ourselves staring across a somewhat exposed ridge at the true peak.



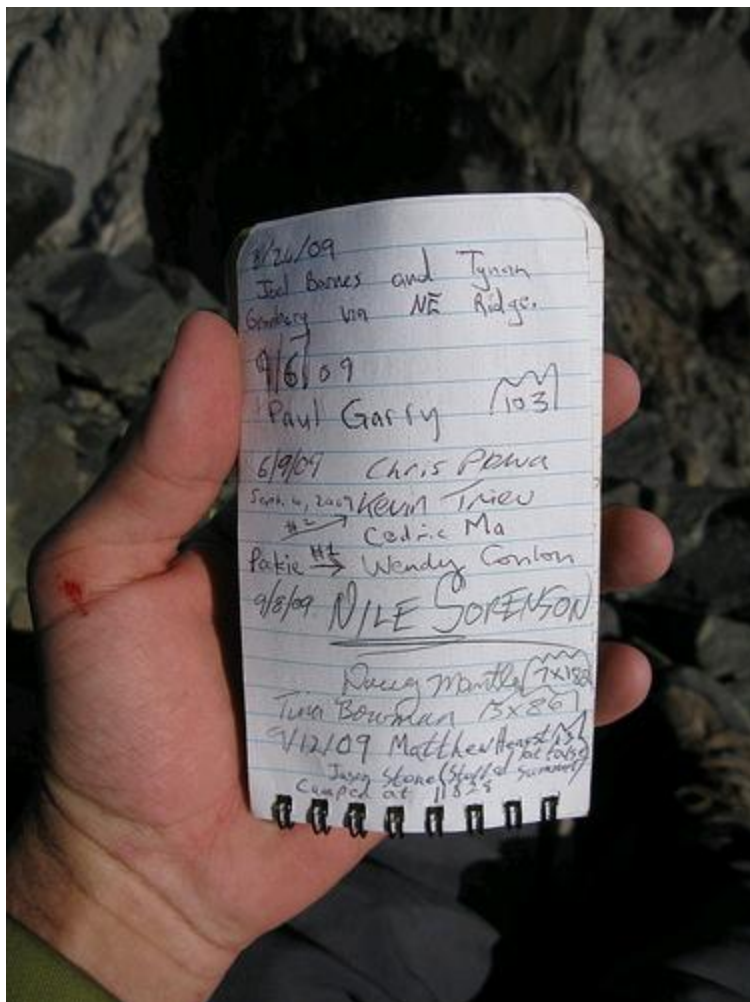
At this point Jason reminded me for the nth time that he was a man with a wife and two children and decided the false summit was plenty for him. I of course couldn't resist and set off across the ridge to the summit.



The biggest obstacle was a large crack running down maybe 12 feet that needed to be down climbed to continue along the ridge. It wasn't the most comfortable descent especially considering the lack of anything but a messy death if you fell but I made my way down with a minimal of cursing while Jason sat above and congratulated himself on a superior survival instinct.

I would have to climb back up the crack to get out but that was a thought for a later time, for now on to the peak!

Soon I was over at the summit and was greeted by a peak register with several familiar names.



Now of course I had to return to Jason and that included climbing back up that exposed crack. As I got there and starting eyeing it I happened to notice a small duck (artificial rock pile) off to the left-hand side.

DOH.

Sure enough there was an easier route around that crack. It made things much less exciting but noticeable safer as I climbed back over to Jason.



I dropped us down the 3rd class second near the peak and the instead of continuing down the ridge took a promising looking scree chute that looked like it could get us down in the general direction of the next peak.



Whoooooooooooooooooooo

Eventually we dropped down to the floor of the canyon and picked our way along several small lakes.



After a time we were approaching peak #2, McDuffie. The area below McDuffie was a small meadow and another lake which is quite an experience walking through. This deep there isn't much traffic with only a handful of people a year max coming through. Generally anyone climbing McDuffie would be coming from the north and never see this.



The weather had taken a somewhat unfriendly turn and as we climbed the last ridge before McDuffie we could see an isolated raincloud dousing Charybdis. Developments like this are partially why I get my groups up so early.

We soon got our own minor shower right about the time we took a shortcut by stripping off our boots and wading across a yet another small lake.





It looked like the weather was going to clear as we started the climb to the peak but sure enough another cloud popped over the ridge and started spattering us. We continued as the rocks grew wet and slippery.

When the hail started I decided to hold us where we were and wait for the weather to break. We put on our rain gear and listened to the sound of the hail bouncing off our helmets.



The hail didn't last too long and I made the decision to continue up the chute as again the weather looked like it was improving. We climbed through a somewhat loose 3rd class section until we reached the summit ridge and skirted around the backside of the peak.

As we approached the summit we could see a rather nasty looking storm forming off to our east. We increased our pace.



We reached the summit and I climbed up to get the register and brought it down about 15 feet below the summit. As this point we heard a few cracks of thunder off in the distance and I wanted us off the ridge as much as possible. We signed, congratulated each other, and headed down the northern slope with the sincere hope we could get off the mountain before we had to start dodging lightning strikes.



The description of the north ridge stated it was a class 2 route which means you shouldn't ever have to use your hands. All well and good but this is what we found.





And that was within a few hundred feet of the summit. Jason was understandably concerned about the whole plunging to his grisly death potential but handled himself well and I was able to talk him through the downclimb.

Now on the ridge proper we continued along the “class 2” route.



Basically there was about 200' of passable area between the top of the ridge and the point where it cliffed out below. There might have been a class 2 route through somewhere but we had several somewhat dicey 3rd class sections as we had to cut up or down to avoid even worse sections.

At any given spot I had to tell Jason to hold up, climb up, look around, climb down, look around, and then move us along what appeared to be the best path.

One of the more memorable moments happened when the lower route looked impassable and I brought us up to the ridge. It was a knife edge at that point with a small ledge to one side you could edge along one foot at a time. I climbed out and then straddled the ridge to climb a bit further before determining this could not be the route. I climbed back to Jason who was quite happy not to go that way.

The entire process took time and the entire while we were under threat from the storm to the east which appeared to be heading our way.

Eventually we came to a place where we could descend off the ridge which we did quite happily.

Now feeling quite tired we continued on towards Black Giant and our camp. The final peak was accessible from a pass above where we were camped. By the time we reached that point it we were losing daylight and I chose to forgo the last peak to avoid having to rock hop back to camp in the dark. Doing that combined with being tired was a recipe for a broken leg and we were quite a ways away from any help. Besides, Black Giant was the easy walkup peak of the three and we'd done the hard two.



We returned to camp just as it got dark and I forced myself to eat before collapsing on to my sleeping pad. I was exhausted by all the extra climbing on the north ridge of McDuffie.

The next day we broke camp at 8:30 am after I let us sleep in a few extra hours. We had a hard hike out, roughly 14 miles which included crossing back over Echo Col.

It was noticeably colder Sunday morning and we had frost on our tents and the grass as we packed up.



The weather was beautiful and unlike the day before the storm clouds never started forming.



The climb up to Echo Col felt long and the col itself hadn't grown any less steep in the intervening day.



We crossed with care, descended down across the glacier, and eventually returned to trail



The lakes along the way were a brilliant blue under the bright sun.



It took us a total of around 10 hours to hike from our camp at Lake 11,828 to our cars at the Sabrina trailhead. At best the drive from Bishop back to Orange County takes around 5 hours. I was in for a late night.

Jason and I had a quick celebratory dinner at Whitney Café in Lone Pine and both left for home in our respective vehicles.

In the end I made it home but by the time I had everything unpacked so I could be ready for the following weekend I had 40 minutes of sleep before I had to wake up and drive to the airport.

My flights were delayed going through San Francisco airport (not surprising) and then I arrived at the client site still running on almost no sleep I got the news my company had just laid off 12 more people. I hate Mondays.